Mark Tobey

By William C. Seitz

Author

Seitz, William Chapin

Date

1962

Publisher

The Museum of Modern Art: Distributed by Doubleday, Garden City, N.Y.

Exhibition URL

www.moma.org/calendar/exhibitions/2793

The Museum of Modern Art's exhibition history—from our founding in 1929 to the present—is available online. It includes exhibition catalogues, primary documents, installation views, and an index of participating artists.

© 2017 The Museum of Modern Art

objects in the room, this secondary matrix of form was independent of them, and was entirely the product of movement.

What Tobey had conceived, but did not make use of until many years later was, precisely, the structural "animation of space" that underlies most of his mature painting. His cubism was a major step toward the ultimate interpenetration of mass and void. Afterward he could see solid objects, such as those abstractly represented in *Table and Ball* (1936, opposite), as transparent and metaphysical: "I don't need to bother about that solid there.... I can go right through myself and I get here and come up there.... When I got through with this, I was freed from the cube. But it was my own personal experience." Another conclusion, more truly "cubist" than the paintings of Picasso and Braque, was that "all life is six-sided, so it's all cubic. Even a piece of paper has six sides; my finger does; my hand does. Everything is six-sided." Almost more important, the principle of moving line was inaugurated. The path of an imaginary fly was to become a metaphysical symbol.

TENG KUEI

The freely moving brush was the second discovery Tobey made in Seattle. In 1923 he began to learn the technique of Chinese calligraphy from Teng Kuei, a young Chinese artist studying at the University of Washington. It was an experience for which Tobey had been prepared by his early infection with "the handling bug" and his subsequent conversion to Bahá'í, with its doctrine of union between East and West: "All is in motion now. A design of flames encircles the quiet Buddha. One step backward into the past and the tree in front of my studio in Seattle is all rhythm, lifting, springing upward!

"I have just had my first lesson in Chinese brush from my friend and artist Teng Kuei. The tree is no more a solid in the earth, breaking into lesser solids bathed in chiaroscuro. There is pressure and release. Each movement, like tracks in the snow, is recorded and often loved for itself. The Great Dragon is breathing sky, thunder, and shadow; wisdom and spirit vitalized."[84] What Tobey learned from Teng Kuei, but did not apply until later, was "the difference between volume and the living line"—a means of opening solid form, giving tangibility to empty space, and of breathing life into static Western realism.

Of course Seattle gave Tobey many things other than these peak experiences. He was aware of the closeness of the Orient which, in San Francisco, came "rolling in with the tides."[85] But Seattle seemed pocketed. "I have often thought that if the West Coast had been open to aesthetic influence from Asia, as the East Coast was to Europe," Tobey wrote in 1957, "what a rich nation we would be!"[86] More keenly than Seattle's proximity to the Orient he felt the broad sweep of mountains, sea, and forest surrounding the city, and the need for "uplift work" which "begins when you leave Grand Central Station."[87] Psychologically the only exit from Seattle, Tobey felt, was toward Alaska. He became a collector of the carving, weaving, and painting of the Northwest Coast Indians. As works like *Drums, Indians and the Word of God* (page 66) attest, Indian art made a mark on his own.

DARTINGTON HALL

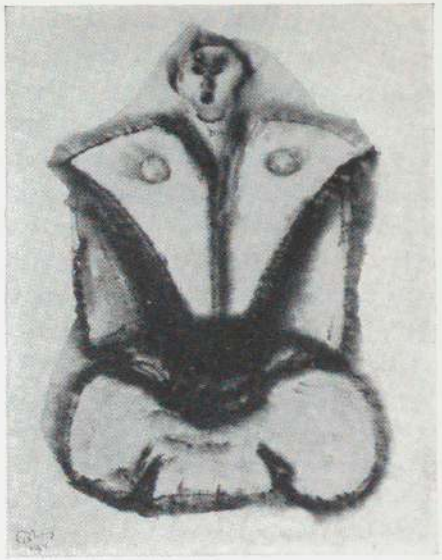
In an article published in Seattle in 1931 mourning Tobey's departure for England he is described as "the stepson of the furies," as "the most vital personality I have seen," whose "emotion blows hot, blows cold," but is never calm.[88] He must have been a dashing and commanding figure. But as his second New York exhibition, held at Romany Marie's Café Gallery in 1929, verifies, his painting was not yet mature. The catalogue alleged him to be a surrealist, but realistic paintings like *Middle West* hung beside undulating abstractions (page 48), and still life beside bizarre fantasies. This was the exhibition of an individualistic and experimental artist who, though he had traveled extensively and had lived in both New York and Paris, was not in touch with avant-garde art. As the first major article on Tobey (written in 1930 by Muriel Draper) states, in the twenties he did caricatures, illustrations, portraits, still life, wood and clay sculpture, landscapes, mural de-

sign, and abstraction. He worked in almost every painting medium, and on any kind of support that was at hand. His prodigious gift had not yet been disciplined and channeled, and some of his most concentrated art, as Miss Draper properly states, tended toward "intellectualized philosophy in paint."[89]

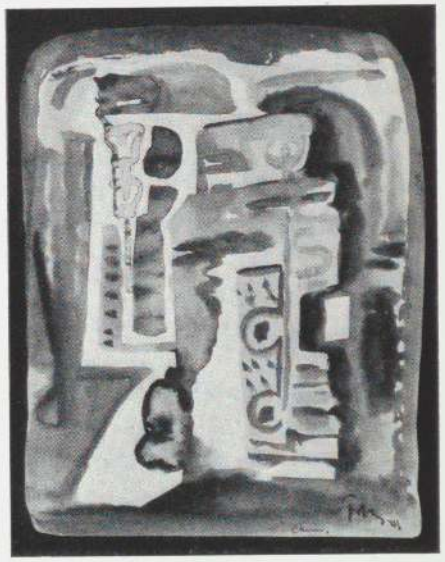
Dartington Hall, a school and cultural center in Devonshire, some 200 miles from London, was Tobey's home between 1930 and 1938. Here he taught, and met such artists and intellectuals as Aldous Huxley, Pearl Buck, Arthur Waley, and Rudi Shankar, all devoted, as Tobey was, to a marriage of Eastern and Western ideas. According to Janet Flanner, Dartington Hall "was the center of the most importance educative experiments of this period."[90] The school was housed in a venerable monument of English architecture, and set in a grove where it seemed "that Pan still lived behind the old oak trees."[91] Tobey found in Devonshire a haven away from the clamor of New York and the provincialism of America. "The nights were so silent you could hear the horses breathing." "My ideal of life," he said in 1962, "would be–well, if not the portico of the philosophers–at least learning amidst trees. I mean an ideal setting of nature and yet the finest core of men's minds. . . ." Dartington Hall was the sanctuary from which Tobey left, sponsored by Mr. and Mrs. Leonard Elmhurst (who supported the school), for his crucial visit to China and Japan in 1934, and it was at Dartington Hall that, after returning the next year, his distinctive style originated.

CHINA AND JAPAN

Tobey stayed with the family of his friend Teng Kuei in Shanghai, living the ordinary life of the city. He became familiar with native foods, amusements, theaters and concerts; he looked at painting and sculpture, and met artists and musicians. In careful detail, his experiences are recorded in his diary. Later he traveled alone to Japan, where he saw No drama, Kabuki, Japanese painting and flower arrangement. He passed a month in a Zen monastery in Kyoto talking with the abbots and monks, at-



Seated Japanese Figure. 1934. Ink, $14^{3}/_{4} \times 11^{1}/_{2}$". Seattle Art Museum. Eugene Fuller Memorial Collection



China. 1934. Ink, $9^{1}/_{2} \times 7^{1}/_{4}$". Collection Mr. and Mrs. Max Weinstein, Seattle

1918 November 11: Tobey and Janet Flanner (later a well-known writer for *The New Yorker*) celebrate the armistice (see page 45).

1919-1920 Reacts against the "Renaissance sense of space and order," and against sculptural form, moved by "a violent desire to break and disintegrate forms and to use light structures rather than dark." Paints *Descent into Forms*, now lost, and compositions "full of minute forms or patterns."

1920-1922 Tobey remembers the twenties as a period of great confusion and brilliance. Draws caricatures, which become popular. *The Circle* by Somerset Maugham plays in New York and Tobey draws John Drew, Estelle Winwood, and others. Some are published in *The New York Times*—one of Lillian Gish "with her hand in her mouth."

1922-1923 Does drawings of burlesque, vaudeville, Harlem dancers, and prostitutes. At the home of a girl who is a highly paid writer of scenarios for Hollywood, Tobey reads an account of a saying by St. Augustine, "We learn to do by doing." After an unsuccessful marriage, he decides to leave New York and apply this principle as a teacher of art. Goes to Seattle and finds a job in a progressive school of art, music, dance, and theater run by Miss Nellie Cornish, and is sponsored by Mrs. Edgar Ames. He is paid $2.00 a class from which the school takes $1.20, and begins teaching with four pupils. One evening at the Cornish School he makes what he now calls his "personal discovery of cubism" (see pages 45–47). Sees a few Japanese color prints.

1923-1924 Meets Teng Kuei, a Chinese student at the University of Washington, who introduces Tobey to Chinese brushwork (see page 47).

1925 June: goes to Europe; settles in Paris on the rue de la Santé. Spends the winter at the home of his friends the Sanderses, in Châteaudun, near Chartres.

1926 January: travels with the Sanderses to Barcelona, Greece, Constantinople, and Beirut; makes a pilgrimage to the tombs of Bahá'u'lláh in 'Akká and 'Abdul-Bahá in Haifa. Intrigued by Persian and Arabic scripts. February: returns to Paris, living in the rue Visconti.

1927-1929 Returns to Seattle, then divides his time between New York, Chicago, and Seattle. Carves some 100 pieces of soap sculpture, one of which is cast in brass by Howard Putzel, who is later to be influential in the New York avant-garde. During a visit in New York, Teng Kuei asks Tobey, as they look at a goldfish tank in a restaurant window, why Western artists paint fish only when they are dead, and why Western paintings resemble holes in the wall. This further undermines Renaissance concepts in Tobey's eyes.



Figure. c. 1928.
Brass sculpture, h. 3 3/4".
Collection Mrs. Horton C. Force, Seattle

1929 December: one-man show at Romany Marie's Café Gallery (interior designed by Buckminster Fuller). Not a success, but A. H. Barr, Jr., sees it and selects pictures for the exhibition *Painting and Sculpture by Living Americans* at The Museum of Modern Art. Returns to Seattle where his teaching position at the Cornish School is threatened by the depression.

1930 Muriel Draper, mother of the dancer Paul Draper, writes the first major article on Tobey in *Creative Art*. Through the interest of Beatrice Straight, Mr. and Mrs. Leonard Elmhurst invite Tobey to teach (supposedly for six months) at Dartington Hall, their progressive school in Devonshire, England, in a picturesque setting some 200 miles from London.

1931 Trip to Mexico, where Tobey meets Martha Graham, Marsden Hartley, and René d'Harnoncourt.

1931-1938 Tobey is resident artist at Dartington Hall. Among the many intellectuals and artists who teach or sojourn there during this period are Pearl Buck, Arthur Waley, Aldous Huxley, Rabindranath Tagore, Rudi Shankar and his dance company, and the Jooss ballet. Sees Turner's *The Burning of the Ships* at the Tate Gallery.

1932 Travels in Europe. Again visits Bahá'í shrines in Palestine.

c. 1933 Paints dry-fresco murals for the dance school at Dartington Hall.

1934 Granted leave for a study trip arranged by the Elmhursts, Tobey departs for the East with Bernard Leach, a painter and ceramist teaching at the school. They go to Colombo, Hong Kong, and Shanghai, where Tobey stays with Teng Kuei and his family; then, alone, he goes to Japan. Spends a month at a Zen monastery in Kyoto, studying calligraphy and painting, meditating, and writing poetry. Pen drawings done in England on wet paper are published in Japan. In June goes to San Francisco where he paints a series of "the animal world under moonlight" in a hotel room.

1935 November–December: first one-man museum exhibition, Seattle Art Museum. After a brief visit to Seattle returns to England via New York.

c. 1935 Back at Dartington Hall, Tobey paints *Broadway Norm*, *Broadway*, and *Welcome Hero* as a result of his Oriental experiences (see pages 48, 49 and note 47). These pictures synthesize Tobey's major discoveries and initiate the style later known as "white writing."

1937 Experiments with cubist still lifes.

1938 Leaves Dartington Hall for a short visit to New York, but world tension prevents his return to England; paints in a furnished room on 72nd Street. Goes to Seattle. Works for six months on the W. P. A. Federal Art Project. Begins teaching in his studio.

1939 Paints murals for the home of Mrs. John Baillargeon, now owned by Richard E. Fuller, Director of the Seattle Art Museum. The writer Nancy Wilson Ross introduces Tobey to Marian Willard, his future dealer in New York, who buys *Broadway*.

1940 In Seattle, during the 1940s, develops white writing, multiple space, moving focus, etc. Studies flute and piano. Wins Baker Memorial Award in Northwest Annual Exhibition, Seattle Art Museum, with *Modal Tide*, starting a local art controversy.

1942 Marian Willard enters *Broadway* in *Artists for Victory* exhibition at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in December. Wins a $500 purchase prize.

1943 Paints pictures based on three years of study in the Pike Place Public Market, Seattle.

1944 One-man exhibition at the Willard Gallery, New York. Beginning of national reputation.





left: Tobey's teaching studio at Dartington Hall.
right: Detail of Tobey's mural for the dance school, Dartington Hall, c. 1933.